

What is Mindfulness?



Mindfulness is not new to the martial arts. It is not something that only belongs in yoga studios or therapy sessions. As martial artists and athletes, we train both our body and mind to be aware of what is going on inside and outside of us. When training katas and techniques, we pay attention to where each part of the body is at any given moment. We notice our opponent's body language to predict their next move. In a sense, we are already training mindfully.

Mindfulness meditation is a state of mind and vantage point from which to observe one's experience and environment. It is a way to bring oneself back to the present moment, non-judgmentally. It is noticing what is, in the here and now — without getting caught up in thoughts, feelings, or body sensations.

You may have experienced this when grappling, sparring, competing, or performing a kata, when you're in a state of flow and everything around you disappears. All that matters is the here and now and your current goal. This is called **mindful awareness**.

History: From Ancient Roots to Modern Practice

Aspects of mindfulness meditation originate from 2,500-year-old Buddhist practices and traditions. In the martial arts, mindfulness can be found in the Daoist concepts of **Zanshin** and **Mushin**.

Zanshin is a spiritual, physical, and mental awareness of yourself within your surroundings so that you can react effectively to attackers.

Mushin (Japanese) or **Wuxin** (Chinese) means "no mind" or "without mind" — a state where the mind is not preoccupied or fixated on one thought or emotion, leaving it more flexible and open. This allows the individual to move freely based on intuition, beyond the obstacles of hesitation or self-judgment. This mental

state is also described as a state of "flow."

Modern pioneers including Jon Kabat-Zinn, Herbert Benson, Richard J. Davidson, Sharon Salzberg, and Jack Kornfield have brought mindfulness into contemporary secular settings: schools, the military, boardrooms, and now — the dojo.



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